

The Cost of COMPROMISE

The Congress may have outplayed a divided Opposition in Parliament but the victory only highlights the paralysis of governance and time for Manmohan Singh and Sonia Gandhi to assert their political authority

By Prabhu Chawla

Was it the day of the Conquistador? When the Government survived the cut motions in Parliament, the UPA masters were a study in political triumphalism. It was a victory built on the wreckage of the Opposition, and their smugness was partly justified by their ability to make best use of the divided enemy camp. It also gave them that much-needed adrenaline rush on the eve of the ruling coalition's first anniversary. So, now that IPL nights are over, isn't it the ideal time for the UPA after-party? Imagine the hosts—Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and Congress president Sonia Gandhi—indulging their most important guests, among them such honourable worthies like Mayawati, Shibu Soren and Mulayam Singh Yadav, whose benevolent gestures made the Golden Tuesday possible. With such friends to count on in the time of acute political anxiety, the Government, headed by not your average politician but a global statesman in the making, can be sure of overcoming bigger existential crises.

The shallowness of the cut motion victory tells a sordid saga of opportunism, compromises, and a blatant repudiation of political morality. One look at the ladies and gentlemen who came forward to ensure the survival of the Manmohan Government will reveal the darker side of the victory—and the price they may have extracted from the Government. Or the moral price the UPA may have paid for just being in power. For instance, Shibu Soren, and these two words stand for the worst instincts of Indian politics. The vote of the Jharkhand chief minister, an ally of the BJP in the state, and a man whose back story is a narrative in crime and punishment, alone will take the sheen out of the UPA victory.

Then there is the lady from Lucknow, who also happens to be the singular force that neutralises Rahul Gandhi's admirable battle for regaining the dynasty's *karmabhoomi*. Quite possibly unsolicited, she provided a lifeline to the Government. Would Delhi now dare to be ungracious

SONIA NEEDS TO
take a refresher course
in the ways of the
original Mrs G, one
smart leader who
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Manmohan Singh
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Dr Moderation with a
bit more political savvy.

to the magnanimous Mayawati? And what would be its effect on Rahul's revival struggle in Uttar Pradesh? Maya is not the one who plays the game without a winning plan. She cannot, beyond a point, keep the Centre as a permanent antagonist, especially when she has the habit of getting embroiled in legal controversies. Manmohan may still aspire to be a stickler to political decencies but can he, or for that matter his party, rage against the transgressions of the autocrat in Lucknow with a clear conscience? Interesting days are ahead.

Equally dubious is the strategic absence of the foxy Yadavs—Mulayam and Lalu, both pillars of the Third Front and 'victims' of Congress's highhandedness. It cannot be just the elasticity of secularism alone that has made them the friends of the Congress for a day. It may very well

